Our only worry was Michael Owen. For a change, the fuss was about his groin instead of my foot, although I don't remember many people, even inside the England camp, being aware of how close he was to missing the Brazil game. He was struggling with a groin strain, the kind of injury that feels worse and worse each time you play through it. Liverpool would have rested him for a couple of weeks during a Premiership season but Michael was so vital to England: a world-class player who always came up with his best on the biggest occasions. Any team in the tournament would have done everything they could to have him fit enough to start.

We certainly weren't scared of Brazil. The game was an afternoon kick-off, which meant they would probably have an advantage if the conditions were anything like they had been for our game against Nigeria. We trained at the stadium the evening before and it absolutely bucketed down. We all knew that the same again the following day would give us a really great chance. In the hotel later on, I felt like I should build a little shrine to the local weather gods and pray, before going to bed, for more rain. No such luck: I jumped out of bed on the Friday morning and pulled open the curtains. The sun was already high in the sky, beating down on a beautiful day. My heart sank: we were going to have to do this the hard way after all.

I'd never think of using the weather as an excuse. You take what you're given and then go and play your best anyway. Even so, enough people had been saying that, if it was hot, England might struggle. I've wondered since if it got into our heads. A tiny doubt is sometimes all it takes to undermine players' confidence. Before the game, we went out onto the field for ten minutes or so but then came inside to do our main warm-up. The Japanese found a big enough office for us to stretch in. It wasn't ideal. And Michael was getting massaged right up to us going out onto the field. It was a close call, but he played. People know all about what Michael does but he's also tougher than anybody outside the dressing room will ever know. I'd had my time with Richard Smith, the masseur, so I understood exactly what Michael went through to make sure he could start. He wasn't going to miss Brazil for the world.

We started the game really well in Niigata. If the heat was bothering us, it didn't seem to show. We didn't wait for their players to get into any kind of rhythm. Do that and a team like Brazil can have the game won before you've even started to play. We knew we had to defend as a team when they were in possession. We couldn't let them get two-on-one against our players anywhere. When we did have the ball, the job was simple enough: don't give it away and get it into their half quickly. Everyone knows the Brazilians like